Focus Traps

What is it for?

Focus traps are when a keyboard user tries to tab away from a page element (or set of elements), but is unable to do so. There are cases where this is incredibly useful (such as when using modals), but in most cases, focus traps are frustrating to the user. Effectively, a user's focus gets trapped, hence the name 'focus trap'.

How to support it

In most cases, you'll want to be avoiding focus traps. They can be added by accident. Always test your pages using only the keyboard before any changes go live.

If you really do want a focus trap, use a ready-made accessible component like a Modal. It handles the focus trap for you.

NOTE: It’s very important to understand that this highlights focus traps, NOT keyboard traps. A keyboard trap is a bad thing, as that’s when you end up stuck in a modal and you can’t get out of it without using a mouse!

Useful links

- A Primer on Focus Trapping
- How to Build Accessible Modals with Focus Traps